

Presenting the Picture: Profiles of Jews with Tattoos

Introduction:

Even as the prohibition against tattooing is upheld by Orthodox, Conservative, and Reform Judaism, adherents of all these movements as well as others and continue to be tattooed. This chapter will present profiles of Jews who made the choice to indelibly mark their bodies. While the demographics of the respondents vary, comprising of both men and women, covering a wide span of ages from 21 to 58 years-old, from all over the United States and Israel amongst various movements: Conservative, Reform, Humanist, Zionist, and the unaffiliated, the data cannot be taken as scientific. Rather, the profiles of Jews with tattoos can be used anecdotally to suggest a number of things regarding the practice of tattooing from contemporary Jewish perspectives.

As interesting as the incised images on these Jews may be, what is more intriguing is the meaning that is imbued in both the tattoo as well as in the process of tattooing by these respondents. Particularly, what motivates the contemporary Jew to be tattooed? What issues uniquely arise for Jews who make this choice to incise and insert ink into the skin? Finally, what role does the perspective of the past play in their present choice: religious traditions, parental desires, historical circumstances of the Holocaust, etc.? And, what do these Jews with tattoos perceive as the future of tattooing in the Jewish world? The answers to all these questions will be exposed as this chapter presents the current picture of the Jewish engagement with tattooing.

Gender: Female **Age:** 21

City/State of Residency:
Givat Avni, ISRAEL

Movement Affiliation: None

How do you define your Judaism?
Sabra Chilonit (Israeli Born Secular)



Question: Please describe your tattoos.

Answer: I have three tattoos. The first is a sun. The second one is a Japanese tattoo, which means "truth." And the third is a cat.

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: The sun, age 13 – in Haifa
The Japanese tattoo, age 17 – in Tel Aviv
The cat, age 19 – in Greece

Question: Where on the body are your tattoos found? For what reasons were your tattoos placed there?

Answer: The sun is on my ankle.
The Japanese tattoo is on my shoulder.
And the cat is on my belly.

I chose those places because you can't always see them. So, sometimes they are hidden. Sometimes they show.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoos?

Answer: Everybody

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoos changed from when you first got it? If so, how?

Answer: No.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: Mostly, just because I liked it. However, one time I went with my friends, who were going to be tattooed. And, there I decided spontaneously to be tattooed as well.

The Japanese symbol was just a spontaneous decision that my ex-boyfriend and I got when we passed a tattoo store and we wanted to do something crazy. It means "truth" in Japanese. The first thing I think about when I look at it is to be true to yourself.

I got the cat symbol with my friend. We were in Greece, she decided to do her first tattoo and I decided to do one also. I like cats a lot and people always say that I remind them of a cat. The first thing I think of when I'm looking at it is my friend. She was my best friend during that time of my life.

Just like the sun, I try to be a warm person and I also like summer. I like it when it is hot. I can't stand the cold. The first thing I think of when I look at the tattoo is how I regret it. I think it is ugly although I like what it means but just not what it looks like.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: I began to like tattoos when I saw them on my friends and thought it was a really neat way of expressing myself. I thought about my first tattoo for a few weeks before I got it. Each tattoo means something special to me and they each symbolize a part of my life. I remember feeling excited to do something “wrong” and it was nice that my parents were the only parents to give permission to get tattoos, since the minimum legal age to be tattooed in Israel is 16. In fact, my father came with me to get it. So, there really was not an issue, besides thinking about what I wanted permanently on my skin.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: See above.

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: No, but the religious people in Israel do look down on you. But it is not like they would even talk to me anyway. And, so what about what the religion says?! It really doesn't matter if I will not be buried in a Jewish cemetery. I will be dead. Even so, it still isn't right. Anyway, right now, I would like my body to be cremated and spread in the ocean.

Question: Does tattooing or being a tattooed Jew in Israel raise any unique issues that may not arise for Jews in other parts of the world? If so, what are these issues?

Answer: No. Not in my opinion.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: I think Jews in Israel are starting to expect that people are going to tattoo themselves (including the religious).

Gender: Female **Age:** 27

City/State of Residency: Stowe, Vermont

Movement Affiliation: None

How do you define your Judaism?

To be quite honest, it is the religion that I consider myself mostly because both my mother and my father, and their mothers and fathers were Jewish. I am not by nature a religious person. By no means does my Judaism define me, thus my getting a tattoo.



Question: Please describe your tattoo.

Answer: I have one tattoo. It is a black “hand of God” or some might refer to it as a “purple hand of Reiki” (if it were purple). A hand, fingers spread with a spiral on the palm.

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: I was tattooed at 25. It was a birthday present to myself.

Question: Where on the body is your tattoo found? For what reason was your tattoo placed there?

Answer: It is on my right hip. It was after much debate that I decided to get it there. I knew that I did not want to have a visible tattoo. I dreaded the thought of being 80 and having some awkward tattoo imprinted on a clear and visible body part. I also chose that area because when I get pregnant, and I intend to, the location of the tattoo will make it appear that the hand is cradling the baby.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoo?

Answer: My tattoo was for me. Nobody else. If I am wearing a bathing suit you can see just the finger tips. My boyfriend at the time thought it was cute but essentially the tattoo was something I really wanted for me.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoo changed from when you first got it? If so, how?

Answer: No, not at all. I don't foresee it ever changing. The idea was for it to protect me and promote good energy. Both the hand of God and of Reiki does these things.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: I have a necklace of a mezuzah. It is beautiful. People compliment me on it all the time even though majority of people have no idea what it is and what it represents. At the end of the day I can take it on and off and change to something else. I could put on a cross or wear a Chinese symbol that even I don't know what it means. There is nothing special about a pendant or even a poster. I liked that I had a strong enough feeling about something that I was

willing to wear it forever. I have struggled with my religious beliefs but I knew from the moment I saw the healing hand that I wanted a tattoo of it. And even more, I loved that regardless of where I was in life, pregnant, old, young, clothed or naked it would be with me. If I want people to know about it, I can show them or if I want it to be special and personal I just keep it to myself. A necklace can fall off, a painting can fall off the wall. I will never lose my tattoo.

I have always wanted a tattoo. I think it is just another beautiful form of art. I liked the process of finding the right tattoo and the right place to put it, and then choosing the artist. I have a lot of piercings and so this was just another way of expressing myself. It was never meant to upset people, especially not my family.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: For my mother, her main concern was that I went to a reputable place. She wanted to make sure I didn't get a disease or infection. She also didn't want me to get something I would later in life regret. For my father it was very much religious. He was strong in his feelings about it being mutilation and more importantly sacrilegious. He continued to remind me how Jews were "tattooed" with numbers in the Holocaust. I knew I could not be buried in a Jewish cemetery once I got one, but religion has never run my life.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: I took everybody's thoughts into consideration. I am extremely close with my mother and father and would never, ever have gotten a tattoo if I thought it would jeopardize my relationship with either of them. However, I needed them to know how important it was to me.

Every year for my birthday I do something for myself. I have colored my hair, had piercings, gone on vacations and the year I got my tattoo I wanted to do something even bigger than before. I told them that. That it was something I had thought and thought about and that it was something that would make me happy, and feel complete.

Obviously as mentioned before my father more than anybody was upset. He brought up his concerns and I did think about them. I definitely took a week to reflect on the idea of getting a tattoo, the consequences but I decided what I wanted was to get it, regardless. The night before I had my appointment I called up my mother and my father and told them that tomorrow I would be getting a tattoo. I apologized if it upset them and explained how excited I was and that they should just be happy for me since that is "all they ever want for me."

In the end they understood I meant no insult to my religion or the people who have suffered in the past getting tattooed for the wrong reasons and without a choice. It is an artistic expression and in the end they were understanding and even liked what the end result was.

I went to visit my father about a month or so after I got the tattoo. Though the idea of a needle freaks my father out, and the initial sight of the tattoo “made his knees weak,” he paused after a moment of looking at it and said... “huh, it is actually kinda cool.” I replied, “I knew you would like it...you know you want one too!!!” He laughed and said, “I wouldn’t go that far.” Now that it is all said and done it is just another part of me. It is never mentioned or pointed out. My mother just kept checking in and making sure it was not infected. She is a mother so my health was most important. She was always just happy to hear I was in no pain and that I was keeping it clean.

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: I did decide to get the hand of God because friends of my family had brought me back a pin that had the hand of God on it from Israel. I loved what it represented and that I could almost justify getting something that was frowned upon in my religion by getting a religious symbol. I did not get it for that reason but it certainly made the decision easier.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: That is a tough question. I know there are and always will be people like me that will disregard what our religion “tells us” and will get tattoos. There is a stigma, I suppose, but I don’t feel it. Had I held my religion higher, things might have been different. This is not to say I don’t respect being Jewish, I just have never allowed it to play a significant role in my life. I don’t see the Jewish world changing their beliefs on whether it is right or wrong. I think people need to decide for themselves. I hope that my “God” still loves me, despite my actions. In the grand scheme of things, people have done much worse things than tattoos so I feel at peace with my decision.

Gender: Female **Age:** 27

City/State of Residency: Phoenix, Arizona

Movement Affiliation: I grew up Conservative, but I would say I am more Reform/non-practicing if anything.

How do you define your Judaism? A family culture



Question: Please describe your tattoo.

Answer: My tattoo is very small and is located on the lower part of my back. It is a purple letter “M” in cursive and below the downward point of the letter there is a blue teardrop. The “M” is for Madonna. The teardrop I guess represents a longing to be a strong individual like she is. I also just liked the visual appeal to it.

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: 17

Question: Where on the body is your tattoo found? For what reason was your tattoo placed there?

Answer: Lower back near the tailbone. It is a spot that I was able to hide it from my family and the public.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoo?

Answer: ME! And anyone I chose to show it to.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoo changed from when you first got it? If so, how?

Answer: Nope. Although I have considered removing or covering it up with a different design. I chose not to because it is part of who I am/was.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: I have the right to decorate myself as I wish.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: Of course! Aging, stretch marks, fading of the design, visibility for work reasons and hiding it from the family, it’s meaning, and if it was something I really wanted to live with the rest of my life.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: Well, the location is great. It is easy to hide and I don’t see it every day. Sometimes I even forget it is there. Personal issues I guess I still face. Others, along with myself, laugh at the meaning of it. I just keep thinking that I have

admired this individual for so long, she is obviously a part of who I am. Even if I don't agree with everything she has done.

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: Yes. I thought about religious so-called consequences, but I believe that God or whatever higher power there is won't judge us in the end whether or not we decorated ourselves. People are artists and if they want to show that on their own body, so be it.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: I think the future is here. So many Jew already have them. I believe more figures in the religious practice are becoming more open-minded regarding the ideas of tattoos.

Gender: Female **Age:** 29

City/State of Residency: Boston, Massachusetts

Movement Affiliation: Reform, because I was raised as such. But now I think I might be a little Humanist.

Picture Not Yet Available

How do you define your Judaism?

I'm really not religious at all in the sense that I do not believe in God (to the point where I actually wonder how anyone can in fact believe in any real way in stories which are clearly fictional). Intellectually, I find myself - in most ways - finding religion to be the root of most human problems. However, I really do still consider myself a Jew for certain aspects of the religion. I like that it is a very personal religion, that the individual must consider what he has done are the actions of a good person or what he has done that he considers bad and must amend his behavior himself. I like that there is a focus on being a good person on this earth, on compassion and righteousness, and not on what will happen to you after you die. I am rather an existentialist, and Judaism (especially post-WWII) fits with that philosophy in many ways.

Question: Please describe your tattoo.

Answer: It's the outline of a crescent moon with a face, and there are swirls inside the outline of the moon. It's black (no color).

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: 23

Question: Where on the body is your tattoo found? For what reason was your tattoo placed there?

Answer: It's on my lower stomach/upper thigh of my left leg. It's there so no one can see it, even if I'm in a bathing suit. I got it there because I wanted one, but I'm also aware that I think that older women with visible tattoos are tacky, and I don't want anyone to see it unless I want them to. Also, I got it there because my parents are very against tattoos and I didn't (and even at almost 30 I continue to not) want them to see it.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoo?

Answer: Only people that I wanted to see it (I suppose from its location, it would mostly be people with whom I am intimate). On the first day that I got it, though, I went out that night and was showing everyone because I was pleased that I had gotten one.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoo changed from when you first got it? If so, how?

Answer: Interesting. I don't know that my tattoo had an intended message. This kind of goes with the next question, but one of the reasons that I got that particular tattoo is actually because I had been drawing that symbol for ages – I tend to draw all the time, especially when sitting in class. On the inside cover of the Smashing Pumpkin's Melancholy and the Infinite Sadness album is a little scene with flowers and such and this cartoonish crescent moon with a face. I just picked up and that scene and that image and started drawing it and I drew it everywhere, all the time. It became my symbol.

The thing is – and this gets to how the “message” has changed – The Smashing Pumpkins and that symbol and drawing while sitting in class in high school has all come to symbolize my youth to me. It was just such a time of possibility, and the music of the time was such a big part. Listening to the Smashing Pumpkins and music like that and being young, the world seemed so infinite. So, while I knew for a while that that was the symbol I wanted as a tattoo, I also knew that I wanted to wait and get it while I was on the cusp of the next phase of my life. I got it when I just finished grad school in Australia and moved back to Connecticut and before I moved to Boston to start teaching. I guess in that sense it has become a farewell to my childhood and youth and an appreciation of myself as an adult, where I can get a tattoo and feel justified that it was the right decision and not a whim of youth.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: Again, this is a corollary to the last question. It has to do with asserting the benefits and joys of the stage of life that comes after youth. But, to be frank, it also has to do with the fact that I just think it's cool and I wanted a tattoo. It's also a little sexy.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: Yes. The big one, as aforementioned, was that my parents are really entirely against tattooing. They think it's trashy and unprofessional, as well as just stupid because most adults with tattoos look stupid (I actually share this opinion with them in many ways – nothing dumber looking than a woman with saggy old-lady arms sporting a tattoo on her shoulder. One wonders how my opinion of my own tattoo will change. Perhaps that will symbolize yet another phase in my life). My apologies that I can't say with any certainty that it has to do with Judaism that they are against it, but I imagine it is part of their dislike for the practice. My grandmother was in Auschwitz and certainly I have always associated their feelings on tattoos with the mandatory tattooing done on victims there. This is one of the reasons I got it in a place where they could not see it.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: Partly, I got it done in a place where no one could see it. Also, thanks to denial and the power of the human mind to ignore consequences, I decided that if I ever regret getting it, I'll just cross that bridge when I come to it.

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: Yes, in the sense that the taboo against tattooing was a part of my religion, and I was aware of it. It of course crossed my mind that this was the case, so I guess I could say that I did it in willful rebellion against that restraint. But it wasn't so much rebellion, but more just the way that I can comfortably say that I am associated with a religion. I don't think I could be part of a religion that would restrain me from doing something that I have no other problem with other than that it was against the religion. So I feel even more comfortable calling myself Jewish knowing that I can be both Jewish and have a tattoo. Is it hypocritical? Maybe. I don't care.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: As with any custom, where someone is restrained from doing something, it will wane. First of all, as to the general proscription against tattooing in the minds of many, so many people are getting and have tattoos now that, as these people "grow up" and take their places in society, there will be no way for the taboo to continue to exist. Especially in America, the only way to make sure people continue wanting to practice a religion is to make it fit in more easily with people's modern, secular lives. Plus, I've read articles where Jews are actually getting tattoos on purpose to assert their choice over what they do to their bodies, as opposed to what was done to Jews in the camps.

Gender: Female **Age:** 29

City/State of Residency: O'Fallon, Missouri

Movement Affiliation: Conservative



How do you define your Judaism?

Judaism is something that I was born with but turned into something I love and made me who I am today. It has become an important aspect that I want to incorporate in my children's lives.

Question: Please describe your tattoo.

Answer: My first name in Hebrew: Sarah.

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: 21

Question: Where on the body is your tattoo found? For what reason was your tattoo placed there?

Answer: Right above my tailbone. So that no one would be able to see it.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoo?

Answer: Just my husband.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoo changed from when you first got it? If so, how?

Answer: No.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: Simply because it was something that I wanted to do for myself. I wanted a tattoo, but I didn't want something stupid that I would regret one day. My first name would be mine for the rest of my life, so that is why I chose "Sarah." I decided to do it in Hebrew because of what my parents had made me believe for so long – that tattoos were against the Jewish religion. If I was going to be going against Judaism I may as well do it right. Some may believe that this makes no sense, but to me it was perfectly clear. Judaism has and always will be an important part of who I am. Having the Hebrew on my body rather than some random butterfly made me feel even closer to the religion. It helped me to believe that I wasn't the "bad Jew" that my parents tried to make me into.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: My parents had always told me that if I got a tattoo I couldn't be buried in a Jewish cemetery and that it would hurt them deeply for that to happen. My parents were very disappointed in me when they found out about the tattoo

and they tried to get me to have it removed. They even offered to pay for it. I refused.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: It upset me that my own personal decision to have a tattoo was something my parents used to look down on me. I considered letting my parents pay to remove the tattoo (to please them) but realized that I had it placed there for a reason. Having a tattoo didn't make me less of a Jew and I couldn't let my parents make me believe otherwise.

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: Yes. Stated above.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: I think the numbers are going to increase. People are starting to care even less whether the older generation believes that it's against the religion. People are starting to think for themselves.

Gender: Male

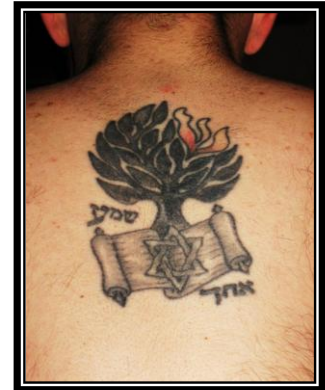
Age: 30

City/State of Residency:
Cincinnati, Ohio

Movement Affiliation: Reform

How do you define your Judaism?

Judaism is a tool which can help one interpret the living texts of the world. The tool of Judaism is equipped with multiple features: history and texts, religion and culture, peoplehood and statehood, philosophy and God. The individual Jew, who wields this tool has the free will, the irrevocable Divine gift that makes us human, to use the features that best help him/her understand life.



Question: Please describe your tattoos.

Answer: I have three tattoos...

- Intertwined *Magen David* (in white and blue) with a dove in the middle, which has an olive branch in his beak.
- Tribal band around right bicep. It incorporates two Stars of David and Eagle Scout symbol. The Hebrew word, *Chai* ("life") is designed as the chest of the Eagle.
- An *Etz Chayim* ("Tree of Life") with 18 leaves to the tree. The tree is on fire, and the flame is in the shape of the Hebrew letter "*shin*." The roots of the tree are twisted into the shape of a *Magen David*, centered on a Torah Scroll. Added to this tattoo are two Hebrew words: *Shema* ("Hear") and *Echad* ("One").

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: (a) 16 – *Magen David* with Dove,
(b) 18 – Tribal Band around bicep, and
(c) 20 – *Etz Chayim*

Question: Where on the body are your tattoos found? For what reasons were your tattoos placed there?

Answer: (a) Left Ankel – *Magen David* with Dove,
(b) Right Bicep – Tribal band,
(c) Center, Upper Back – *Etz Chayim*

They were placed in places that seemed fitting for the design, as well as, in locations that could be hidden when deemed desirable for the social contexts.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoos?

Answer: Primarily myself. In fact, I placed them in spots that are easily covered by clothing, for professional reasons.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoos changed from when you first got them? If so, how?

Answer: The message has not changed. However, I now attribute religious meaning to my first tattoo. Initially I just wanted to be tattooed. At the age of 16, traveling in Israel, I found my chance. It was in a less-than-reputable tattoo shop in Tel Aviv. Yet, I froze when asked what I wanted. Prior to this trip, I had thought of many things: the Tasmanian Devil, a Coke bottle, etc. Something Jewish was the farthest things from my mind. After all, I was a Jew simply because my parents are Jews, and their parents, and their parents before them. Judaism meant no more to me than the color eyes I was born with. I had no choice in accepting them. Yet, had I not like them, I would have found a way to alter their appearance.

On this trip to Israel it was I who was altered. On November 4, 1995, I was just minutes away from the spot Yitzhak Rabin was assassinated. And, before I knew it I was not reading history. I was the history. It was a life-changing perspective. I could continue to read about Jewish history, or I could become an active player in that book, shaping the history of the Jewish people. The moment I was tattooed with a Star of David near my foot, I solidified my place among my people. Wherever I walked, I was accompanied by those who came before me. Specifically Rabin's mission became my mission: peace.

At that time, the message was clear of any religious connotations. It was a mark of identification with the people and the mission of peace. Now that my path of Judaism has continued, I find myself enjoying multiple facets of our people, including the religion. Thus, no longer when I look at the tattoo, does it simply speak to my cultural identity. It is reinforced with my deep religious identification as well, for which we aspire to bring God's peace here on earth.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: (a) *Magen David* – Permanent identification with the Jewish people.
(b) Tribal Band – A reminder of valuable lessons which could guide my life in a period of transition (leaving home and starting out on my own in college). These teachings came from Judaism as well as my time in the Boy Scouts.
(c) *Etz Chayim* – This expresses my perspective on life, balancing my affection for my particular Jewish faith with my universal faith in human kind under one God. Like a tree, which stays rooted to where it was born, I too will stay rooted to the faith from which I was born. Yet, as a tree grows, it branches outward to encompass as much life as possible underneath the protection of its branches. Thus, I too – throughout my life – will branch out to help others. For this reason I added the words, *Shema* and *Echad*. It emphasizes the oneness I hear in my life: one love, one life, and certainly one God that encompasses all diversity. Additionally, the flame is in the shape of

the Hebrew letter “*shin*” for the “*shin*” marks holy vessels for protection. For like the mezuzah, the body is a holy vessel.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: Not with my first tattoo. I was lucky nothing bad stemmed from this experience. In my decision to be tattooed the following two times, I not only considered the cleanliness of the place, but other practical issues like the skill of the artist and the price of the tattoos.

Also, in my decision to be tattooed two more times, I began exploring the Jewish religious perspective on tattooing. I don’t think I would have, had it not been for the rabbi at the Conservative congregation I worked for as a youth advisor. He presented me with the Conservative responsum on the topic, and said that if I desired to continue to work with children it would be advantageous to be informed. I read it and felt – at the time – I was informed on the topic. Nevertheless, I still went on to be tattooed.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: In regards to the practical concerns, I spoke with friends who were tattooed and asked about the tattoo parlor they went to, as well as the tattoo artist they worked with. One of my friends had befriended a local tattoo artist who was recognized in the business. Since I designed my own tattoos, he allowed me to come back to his studio and work from there. It was a very personal process. I couldn’t have asked for a more meaningful experience.

Regarding the second issue over the religion, I realize now I was not as informed as I could have been. Reading one responsum certainly does not equip me with enough information to have made an informed Jewish decision. In retrospect, I first made a decision and then tried to justify it only later through Judaism: both in presentation (including Jewish images) as well as with Jewish texts and thought. I do not regret the decision, for I would still tattoo my body even today. However, I do regret the process, not allowing my tradition to speak more to my decision prior to making it.

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: Not at first, but it certainly does now. The concept of *b’tzelem elohim*, in my view, is wrongly manipulated to convince modern Jews not to tattoo. “Created in the image of God” does not literally mean that our human form is a reflection of God, and that by tattooing we are actually screwing with God’s form. No way, for God has no arms, legs, chest, head, etc, unless individuals choose to anthropomorphize God.

God, rather, is a spirit that exists within and around everything, unifying all diversity. God, in fact, imparts this spirit into each one of us. As it is stated in Genesis 2:7, “God formed man from the dust of the earth and blew into his

nostrils the breath (spirit) of life. Man became a living being.” This is what is meant by *b’tzelem elohim*. Not God’s body, but God’s spirit is bestowed within each of us, within the vessel of body.

This vessel, however, is fleeting. As part of a mortal life, God informs man: “you are dust, and to dust you shall return,” (Gen 3:19). Our bodies are, therefore, temporary vessels which will return to the earth. Nevertheless, why they are here, they house the eternal soul which will one day return to God. It appears, then, that no violation/harm to *b’tzelem elohim* (i.e. the soul) occurs when the vessel (i.e. the body) is tattooed.

I know. Some will argue the exact opposite: tattooing jeopardizes the integrity of this temporary vessel and by extension the eternal spirit it is meant to protect. But, and this is a critical “BUT.” Modern tattooing in most places in the developed world is a highly regularized process by local, state, and national governments, which establish strict guidelines regarding the safety and cleanliness as well as harsh punishments for their violation. These guidelines are even equitable to the sterility of hospital procedures, as tattooing is considered a surgical procedure.

Thus, I believe, tattooing does not harm the soul (which is in the image of God). Particularly my tattoos, importantly and valuably, express the soul and even express my understanding of God.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: From my understanding of the prohibition, and many similar prohibitions, tattooing was forbidden as a way to make the Israel nation and its members distinct from its neighbors. Does not the tattooing of Jewish symbols and messages accomplish this task – distinguishing an individual as a Jew? Sure, it was not the way that the rabbis had intended for Judaism to be distinct, but does that mean it is any less valuable and credible of an approach? In fact, the Pharisees of the Second Temple began a movement, which rabbinic Judaism comes from, to democratize Judaism – making it more available and accessible to all the people, not just the Sadducees (priest) of the Temple.

Are we to go back on the spirit of movement of openness and change by saying that only rabbis can have a credible approach to God’s teachings? Therefore, to empower every Jew to make Jewish decisions in the future, I think Jews need to be better informed about the tradition. This does not mean that we will abide by its rules. But, understanding the why: whether *why* one accepts the tradition or *why* one does not accept the tradition allows the choice of the individual Jew to be a Jewish choice. Possibly, the Jewish path of tattooing in the future will reside in between these two extremes of outright rejection and outright acceptance.

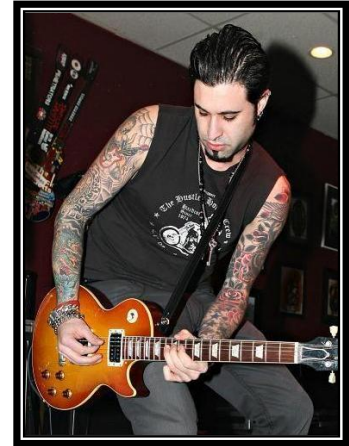
Gender: Male **Age:** 30

City/State of Residency: Hollywood, California & New York City

Movement Affiliation: Reform

How do you define your Judaism?

I believe that Judaism is something within yourself. It's how I feel in my heart and mind. It's my connection to the Jewish people. It's my pride as a Jew and my understanding of how to allow my religion to continue to the next generation.



Question: Please describe your tattoos.

Answer: Well there are many to describe...

(a) My left arm is an entire martial art piece representing the 5 Kenpo animals with roses intertwined. (b) My right arm is a dragon, Thai flamed art, a web, a hand of God, Hebrew writing that says "only god will judge", and a punk girl with a guitar. (c) My neck has a black widow on it. (d) My chest has a Jewish star in the same spot my relatives in the holocaust wore their yellow star. (e) My leg has a grateful Dead logo on it. (f) My back has an eagle and Chinese writing on my spine.

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: 13 years old, then 16, then 18 and every year since.

Question: Where on the body are your tattoos found? For what reasons were your tattoos placed there?

Answer: I have 2 sleeved arms, large back tattoo, leg tattoos, chest piece, and a neck piece. My tattoos all have significant meaning to me. They represent a time or event in my life that has affected me in some way. It's a way for me to remember certain things that I believe in or should be reminded of. The message to others is to speak of freedom and passion for what I believe and realize.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoos?

Answer: Me and the entire world.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoos changed from when you first got it? If so, how?

Answer: No. they all still remind me of the same things they were supposed to. That will never change.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: Freedom of expression and art. Also, all of my tattoos are things I believe in and want to be reminded of. For example, I have many references to martial

arts, which was a time in my life of intense mental and physical training; a time of control for me and pushing to the limits. My tattoos of a Jewish nature are reminders of my heritage and that my relative fought for freedom from persecution. I have a Star of David on the spot where my family was forced to wear a yellow star during WWII. A time no one should forget and a time I force myself to be reminded of.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: No, I always do things my way and never question others reactions.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: I did not consult my mother. She only saw the tattoos years later and her reaction was crying. She said that our family was tattooed in labor camps and how could I. I explained my view. The tattoos were a memorial and a reminder. After time, she understood. She has no issues anymore, she understands and respects me more now and doesn't question me. She sees the passion I have for them and what they mean to me. Besides the guilt of my mother, no other issue ever came up.

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: Yes, many of my tattoos are influenced by Judaism: Jewish scripture and art.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: Like the rest of the world, it will continue and the Jewish community will begin to realize that the youth have changed. This is a new generation.

Gender: Female **Age:** 33

City/State of Residency: Cincinnati, Ohio

Movement Affiliation: Reform

How do you define your Judaism?

I define my Judaism as the way I live my life. My main focus is on *tikkun-olam*, but I find peace in my Judaism, especially when dealing with difficult situations or people.



Question: Please describe your tattoos.

Answer: Tattoo #1: Two Cat Paws
 Tattoo #2: *Emunah* written in Hebrew
 Both are in dark purple ink.



Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: 30, as a birthday present to myself. At age 30, I also converted to Judaism at Wise Temple, Reform, with Rabbi Michael Shulman. It just felt like coming home and it became part of me instantly.

I was born into a Catholic family, but not really raised in the faith as in no formal classes, training, etc. Including, I did not receive any information about tattooing from that faith tradition. We never really talked about the religion and any time I was in a Catholic Church, I felt out of place. I never felt right and I could never come to grasp/reconcile/understand the idea of more than one God. The first time I sat in a synagogue it was if I had come home.

Question: Where on the body are your tattoos found? For what reasons were your tattoos placed there?

Answer: Tattoo #1: The Cat Paws are on the outside of my right ankle.
 Tattoo #2: *Emunah* is on the inside of my right ankle.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoos?

Answer: I did not really think about this at first. I placed them on my ankle to ensure that I would see them, but I really did not think about who else would see them. However, I did realize that they would be noticeable to other people, but not necessarily the first thing people would notice about me. Of course, at first, I showed them off to my friends!

I teach High School and this particular year I had sophomores and juniors for Social Studies. Because I got them in March, my students knew that I was getting them because they heard me talking about it with colleagues and they

eagerly joined the discussion. They were very concerned about what I was choosing, why I chose it, where I was putting it, color, style, etc. However, the following year with my new group of students, I was stunned at how fast they saw them on my ankle! Now, it is a fun game I play with myself to see which brave new student will ask first about them.

They are always intrigued to find out the meaning of the Hebrew tattoo. They don't know any Jews, so I am an anomaly. Many of them do not even know it is Hebrew at first. They don't really react. They just sort of nod or say "hmmm." They very rarely ask why. Some of my juniors, who I have since they were freshmen, have asked why I chose it in the past two years and I explain. A couple of the girls have asked to touch it as well, but I did not ask why. It is a bit raised, so it does have a feeling as opposed to just blending into my skin. Because this class is so small, I often sit amongst them during discussion and toss my legs up on a chair, so they see it very up close.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoos changed from when you first got them? If so, how?

Answer: No

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: I have always been so conservative, straight-laced, and one who kept to the social norms. So, for my 30th birthday, I decided to be rebellious! People are still surprised to discover that I have two tattoos! It was fun and I chose something meaningful, so I feel like I made the right decision.

I chose the Cat Paws to represent my love of animals and my dedication to the no-kill shelter where I volunteer. These tie into the Jewish idea of *tikkun-olam*. Since I share my home with cats and work largely with cats at the shelter, cat paws seemed the logical choice. Also, dog paws would be way too large or at least, when I think of dog paws, I am thinking large breeds! Two others at the shelter have a similar tattoo, but each is unique to the tattoo artist and the person.

I chose *Emunah* because when I converted to Judaism (of my own free will not due to my previous marriage), I finally learned what faith meant: Even though you can't touch it, see it, rationalize it, it is still possible and it can happen. It had always been such a hazy concept in my mind, but one day I was sitting at Shabbat services and the rabbi was discussing faith. It was like a beam of light suddenly opened in my mind and it illuminated a new part of my mind. I remember smiling and feeling myself physically relax. I wanted to place this word on me in a place where I could never forget or if I needed a reminder, I could touch my ankle. I think this is why I chose to place on the inside. I also wrote the word myself, so that was significant, too. When you choose Yisraela as your Hebrew middle name...faith is really important!

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: No. However, now school districts are considering mandating that tattoos not be visible during the school day, so I do not know how I will handle this if this should become an issue.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: N/A

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: In addition to the answer above, I also did think about the tattoos as being symbolic of the Holocaust survivors particularly those in Auschwitz. These Jews did not receive their tattoos by choice and their marks were a reminder of horrific times.

For me, I feel like my *Emunah* tattoo honors their struggle of survival, and to a certain extent, expresses the idea that modern Jews have the choice of being tattooed with Jewish symbols that bring glory to Judaism rather than shame.

I don't write poetry or sing or dance. I consider my tattoo a piece of art because I wrote it. I read in *My Mother's Eyes*, by Anna Ornstein, about how she sought out the best "tattoo artist." She had enough pride in herself to want a neat mark inscribed in her. My action reflects her actions and I feel honors her.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: On a certain level, tattooing has become a fad for those in their 30s and the generations behind them, so since many Jews are assimilated into main stream society, I think younger Jews will be more tattooed than the baby boom generation. Will a decision have to be made about allowing the burial of tattooed Jews in Jewish cemeteries...perhaps.

I am not sure what other laws of *Halacha* tattooing breaks; therefore, I cannot comment further. However, I did have a rabbi tell me that many ancient Jews did do tattooing, so perhaps a historian should research this and spark conversation amongst rabbis and Jews of all three movements.

Gender: Male

Age: 42

City/State of Residency: Cincinnati, Ohio

Movement Affiliation: Reform

How do you define your Judaism?

A spiritual exploration using the tools of the Jewish religion; a blend of modernity and mysticism.



Question: Please describe your tattoo.

Answer: I have a tattoo on my ankle that is a black band with waves in it.

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: 35

Question: Where on the body is your tattoo found? For what reason was your tattoo placed there?

Answer: Ankle, it was able to be private but also viewable when I wanted it to be. As a rabbi, we are role models of Jews - whether we want to be or not. When someone finds out you are a rabbi, they watch what you eat more carefully. They watch how you behave more carefully. And, so to have a tattoo, they can say: "Well, I know a rabbi who has a tattoo." You become the Jewish representative. For non-Jews especially, because their litmus tests are priests, imams, ministers, which are held in high regards in their systems. Whether or not we as rabbis are held in high regards by our own system is another question. If I am a role model to people, then I need to be seriously careful about the aspects of my life that are public, which is the reason that I chose to get the tattoo in a place that I could show it to people that I want to show it to.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoo?

Answer: All.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoo changed from when you first got it? If so, how?

Answer: No.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: The tattoo represented a struggle through trauma and the source of strength in all times of darkness, the wave. I waited until I had finished rabbinical school which was a real struggle for me. Just in general it was a very hard time and I had some childhood trauma that I was working through. At that point, I had some breakthrough on it. I saw the tattoo representing the kind of opportunity to show the darkness on the outside of the tattoo and the hope was the water on the inside of the tattoo. Even in tough times in my life I find the ocean very, very powerful as a metaphor and also as hope.

Also, I always wanted the tribal style tattoo, because I am connected to that tribal aspect of life. Thus the tattoo represents that tribal physical strength, as well as that inner strength too. If I had known how much it was going to hurt with the black [work] it might have been different. Yet, I think the pain was a good aspect for me. Kind of like a rite of passage, like I wanted to experience getting something beautiful out of something harder. I think it comes back to the concept of earning something. Like in tribal societies I think you earn your place through acts of bravery, acts of going through something difficult. Any good decision in your life goes through that, it might not be physical pain. It could be emotional pain, struggle.

I mean, I tried other mediums. I had tried painting. I had tried writing. I had tried physical sculpture. I had tried exercise. I tried everything else. And this decision to be tattooed seemed to be a commitment to the fact that, especially in relation to the trauma aspect of it, this is my wound; this is my mark. I identify so much with Jacob - the story of Jacob wrestling - that he walks with a limp afterwards; or Isaiah as the wounded healer. Like this was my mark. I look at this tattoo I remember always that I went through this very difficult time and I am still standing. That's why the tattoo... it's permanent.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: No.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: None.

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: Yes. As a rabbi I needed to examine the decision seriously and also know that some wouldn't understand it. I started looking at the Torah text and then I moved to the *Mishnah* and Talmud. I knew I wanted to get a tattoo. So, maybe that colored my way of looking at the text. I didn't believe the whole thing about not getting buried in a Jewish cemetery, as keeping me away from that decision.

I run a different kind of rabbinate than a lot of people anyway. I kind of go at the beat of my own drum. I always have. To get a tattoo was not a big deal on that part. But, as I have matured into the role and realized the responsibility of it, it changes the way I look at it. I still don't give a crap what people think. To a certain extent, this is who I am. The people that are not going to understand are also going to be the people who are not going to understand other things about me either.

"What do I do as a teacher of young people, who might have parents who don't want them to get a tattoo, and might feel that if the rabbi has one, why can't I have one?" I have to be careful about the advice that I give. I never tell

a kid go and get a tattoo. But I say, if you are going to get a tattoo, here are the consequences. And the consequences to the action are permanent. If you get Yosemite Sam tattooed on your rear-end, it's permanent and you better like it and it better mean something to you.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: I believe that tattooing has a place in modern society and Judaism, as it grows, will embrace its expression with greater understanding. In fact, I think we are entering a new era for Jews; a place where Jewish pride is going to be a huge piece in constructing the message to younger Jews and even to Jews in their 20's, 30's, 40's.

If you go back to the way Judaism was – pre-rabbinic – I think there were lots of rites of passage that we have lost touch with. I think that tattoo could be a rite of passage. It could be a way of marking ourselves as something... tattooing, historical, has been a sign of becoming a man. I am not suggesting that we tattoo all our Bar/Bat Mitzvah kids. But in our own way, the Bar/Bat Mitzvah is a representation of a struggle through something difficult at a difficult time in our lives. There could be some real powerful stuff with tattooing.

I understand that there are people that see tattooing in relation to the Holocaust. But, I don't see Judaism in relation to the Holocaust. I don't want my Judaism to be a response to the Holocaust. I think it is a mistake. I think the tattoos that people were forced to wear are different than the ones we are choosing as free people. The tattoos of slavery in Egypt are different than the tattoos that might have happened in the Promised Land. So it is taking back that.

I say, be proud of who you are. Be proud of being Jewish. Get a Jewish symbol tattooed on your body and be proud of it.

Gender: Male **Age:** 43

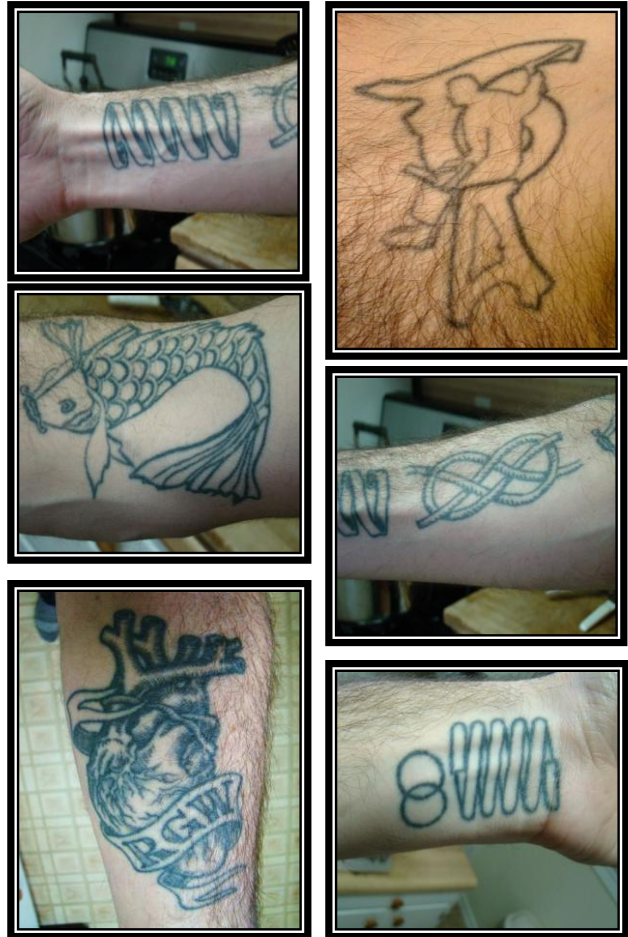
City/State of Residency: Stillwater, Oklahoma

Movement Affiliation:

I was a long time member of *Habonim* (1977-1984), which culminated in a year of volunteer Kibbutz work with 40+/- of my childhood, summer camp friends. After that I became absorbed by my college education in the arts. I have very mixed feelings about the Zionist movement at this point. The Israeli-Palestinian conflict is a very tough nut. I tend to side with the marginalized people in any ethnic, religious or nationalist conflict.

How do you define your Judaism?

At the moment, living in Oklahoma I have never felt so much like a minority, a Jew in a land of beef eating, Jesus loving, republican insular people. But besides the immediate situation I am marginal in my observation of the religion but still very connected to my heritage and educating our six year old about the holidays, the history and the culture.



Question: Please describe your tattoos.

Answer: I have many: on my chest, both inner forearms and above my right ankle. 9 total. I have included 6 images, each having descriptions of the image and the year the ink was applied.

- | | |
|------------------------------|---|
| <i>Left upper chest –</i> | Right Angle, man w/decorative iron background, 1991 |
| <i>Right inner wrist –</i> | Banner without traditional text, 1995 |
| <i>Right inner forearm –</i> | Double Carrick's bend, traditional decorative sailing knot, 1996 (while on honeymoon in Newfoundland) |
| <i>Right inner elbow –</i> | Carp Image from Hawaiian Surfing Shirt, 1998 |
| <i>Left inner wrist –</i> | Hobo rings and mechanical spring, 1995-1996 |
| <i>Left inner forearm –</i> | Human heart with RGW banner, 2000 |

All of my tattoos reflect personal experience, people in my life, visual creativity and sculptural object making. The greater symbolism of the imagery is how I choose to use illustrated imagery as a way to communicate ideas. The sailing knot is self explanatory as a symbol of our wedding vows. The

fish is an adaptation of an old Japanese wood cut image which tells of a boy who is fishing and catches a very large fish who is actually a reincarnation of his grandmother. The fish is so big that while he is reeling it in it devours him. The human heart with the initials and banner is my gift to my wife: taking her maiden name initials after she took my sir name. The hobo rings were a gift from a friend/tattoo artist who shared with me the lore of hobos branding one another with the open end of a hot pipe as a sign of friendship.

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: 24 or 25. I had my first tattoo done in 1989 or 1990 in Colorado by a tattoo artist named Calamity Jane. Her name alone got me interested.

Question: Where on the body are your tattoos found? For what reasons were your tattoos placed there?

Answer: I got my first tattoo above my right ankle. I didn't want to look at it or have it looked at all of the time. Then I got my second tattoo on my chest as a sign or seal or symbol of being creative and human and male. My remaining tattoos are on both of my inner forearms. This "leap" to more visible areas of my body was a conscious decision that took me from the modest phase of being tattooed to the vanity phase. I also considered the effect of the sun on the ink which is why they are on the inner forearm.

Question: Who was intended to view your tattoos?

Answer: No one specifically was "intended" to view them. Yet I make little effort to keep them covered from view. Except for job interviews and exposure to the sun.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoos changed from when you first got them?

Answer: No, I have always thought through the initial concept and drawing thoroughly before approaching the tattoo artist.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: I believe adornment of the body, self mutilation and or voluntary adornment/mutilation is an inherent part of experiencing the human condition, whether it's piercing, branding, circumcision etc. We are the only "beings" that perform these types of acts on ourselves and each other. It is through the daily ritual, sub-cultural interactions and spiritual relations that we participate in these acts. We don't have to experience these acts or images in order to be humans. Yet, if we do experience them as observers or as the subject(s) we stand to gain a broader understanding of our relationship to one another and the creative and spiritual relationship we have to our existential world. We have the capacity to adorn ourselves and the capacity to permanently alter ourselves and it is through these acts that we potentially reconnect to some of the oldest ritual practices in human community. People who do not tattoo are no less human than those of us who do tattoo. People who do not tattoo

participate in other practices and activities that reflect human ritual history and contemporary versions of those rituals.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: I was mainly concerned with the sterility of the needles being used by the tattoo artist. Although I was aware of the potential implications, I was not concerned about burial in a Jewish cemetery. Since I was a young adult I have never really appreciated or understood why we (Western human society) place so much value in burial. I admit I have never researched the history of it either, so my lack of appreciation is somewhat out of ignorance. But from a gut level and from an intellectual/emotional perspective I am much more inclined towards cremation of human remains. This being said, I did momentarily consider how my mother, who is no longer living, would react to my being tattooed in relation to the “ban on burial.” It was a passing consideration that was quickly trumped by my personal interest in permanent body art.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: N/A

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: No.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: Wow!! That’s a big question. Raised as a suburban Philadelphia liberal Reform Jew who has slowly and consistently moved away from any standard religious life style, I’m not sure I can easily approach the question. I do believe that there are acceptable and not acceptable practices within and outside of the Judeo-Christian mainstream. Somehow, tattooing has become marginally acceptable in the general mainstream since the late 20th century. I don’t think however that tattooing will ever be acceptable in the Conservative or Orthodox Jewish culture/religion. I’m not sure there is a need for it to be acceptable in those contexts. At what point do the individual interests and needs of a modern society Jew mesh with the practices and ritual of tattooing? Is there a common ground on which tattooing can expand the perspective of modern Judaism and is there common ground on which modern Judaism can expand the perspective of tattooing?

Finally, I offer a brief anecdote: I had two male students last semester, one in a foundations level design class and the other in an upper level sculpture class, both in their early to mid twenties. Several weeks into the design class I noticed student #1 had Hebrew print tattooed on his inner forearm. I asked him if he knew what the word was and he answered it meant “blessed” as derived from the Old Testament. I asked him if he was Jewish. He said no. I

was fascinated that in central Oklahoma a young adult was individual enough to have Hebrew text tattooed on himself.

Within a week of that interaction, I noticed student #2 had Hebrew text tattooed on his inner bicep (ouch!). I asked if he would rotate his arm out and upon closer observation and with my rudimentary Hebrew skills I read out loud the word mish-pa-cha (family). He immediately asked me how I knew the word and I explained my Jewish background and my *Habonim* history. I asked if he was Jewish and he too said no. So the moral of the story is when in Oklahoma expect to meet at least two young adults, both college art students, both having tattoos incorporating Hebrew text, both interested in the graphic appearance and underlying history of the Hebrew language.

Gender: Female **Age:** 58

City/State of Residency: Cincinnati, Ohio

Movement Affiliation: Reform

How do you define your Judaism?

I observe certain traditions and customs and clearly consider myself ethnically and religiously Jewish.



Question: Please describe your tattoo.

Answer: I have a Maat feather and a lotus flower intertwined. They are symbols of truth/justice and rebirth.

Question: At what age were you tattooed?

Answer: 55

Question: Where on the body is your tattoo found? For what reason was your tattoo placed there?

Answer: My upper arm, that way I can cover it when I want to and display it when I feel comfortable doing that.

Question Who was intended to view your tattoo?

Answer: It's mostly for me, but also for others when I'm around people who are not judgmental about tattoos.

Question: Has the intended message of the tattoo changed from when you first got it? If so, how?

Answer: No.

Question: For what reason(s) did you choose to be tattooed?

Answer: My son is a tattoo artist and I wanted to support his artistic expression. Honestly, at first I was not supportive of my son's chosen profession. Over the years, however, I had the chance to reflect on it more carefully. I think at first it was also a rebellious act on his part - expressing his artistic talent in that way. We both changed our thinking. When I got the tattoo it was also at the time that I received tenure -- so it was a statement on my part too.

Also the symbols of my tattoo are meaningful for me. The Maat and lotus are symbolic of future hope for our world in general. Also, I admire ancient Egyptian culture and the ideas behind their symbols.

Question: Did you need to consider certain issues before getting a tattoo? If so, what issues arose?

Answer: Yes. Mostly I needed to be sure that I wanted to have those marks for the rest of my life.

Question: If certain issues were raised in your decision, how did you deal with them?

Answer: Being Jewish and the biblical prohibition were some issues expressed by others. I don't really think they are applicable in modern times for informed persons. "Informed persons" are thinking adults who don't just follow religious precepts blindly. For non-orthodox persons to consider tattoos a taboo, while they choose not to observe Shabbat or kashrut according to *halacha* seems a contradiction or better yet simply arbitrary and close-minded.

Question: Did Judaism, in any way, play a role in your decision? If so, how?

Answer: Ultimately, no.

Question: What, in your opinion, is the future of tattoos and tattooing in the Jewish world?

Answer: I think tattooing in the Jewish world will become accepted. This can be seen in the rapid rise of the practice in Israel. Making the decision to have a tattoo (or not to have one) should be an individual decision, not one dictated by any rabbi or other authority figure.

Conclusion:

Even from the small sample of 11 respondents, it can be suggested that the practice of tattooing has broad range appeal within the Jewish community. Jews from all over the United States availed themselves of the practice, from the west in California and Arizona to the east in Vermont, Massachusetts, and New York as well as the places in between such as Ohio, Missouri, and Oklahoma. Not only are American Jews engaging in the practice of tattooing, Jews in Israel have also been enticed by the modern trend, as is heard from the resident of Givat Avni in the southern Galilee region of Northern Israel. As the practice is not isolated to one Jewish community, neither is it isolated to one particular generation, as Jews from their early teens to those in their mid-50's have all made the choice to permanently mark their skins with a tattoo. Additionally, tattoo's wide appeal in the Jewish community can be suggested, as marked respondents espoused a connection to diverse enclaves of Judaism: Conservative, Reform, Humanist, Zionist, and the unaffiliated. As geographically, generationally, and socially diverse as this small sample of 11 respondents may be, they all had one thing in common: all 11 made the choice to be tattooed. Yet, underlying the shared decision are personal considerations that will expose the complex Jewish engagement with tattooing in modernity.

Why does the modern Jew tattoo? Concisely, as was stated by one respondent, modern Jews "choose to use illustrated imagery [of a tattoo] as a way to communicate ideas."¹ Despite the common decision to communicate ideas through the incision and insertion of ink underneath the skin as to leave an indelible mark, the underlying meaning respondents imbue in those marks varies. For some the meaning of the tattoo does not

1. This statement comes from the respondent from Oklahoma.

extend far beyond the superficial epidermis, as is heard from the 29 year-old respondent from Missouri: “[I got a tattoo] simply because it was something I wanted to do for myself.” For others, however, the depth of the tattoo as a means of self-expression extends well beyond the physical insertion. The tattoo can be a means to express one’s allegiance to a principle: truth and justice, hope and friendship. It can also express solidarity to a mission, such as volunteer work, or to a people, as is the case of the *Magen David* tattoo on the 30 year-old respondent from Ohio: “The moment I was tattooed with a Star of David near my foot, I solidified my place among my people.”

Still, for other respondents, the tattoo was less about an ideological message and more about a temporal one as the act of tattooing marked the miles on the road of life. In the words of the 29 year-old from Massachusetts, “I wanted to wait and get it [i.e. the tattoo] while I was on the cusp of the next phase of my life.” Out of the 11 respondents, eight chose to be marked by a tattoo as a way to express a moment of transition such as a birthday, wedding, conversion, surviving a trauma, and achieving tenure in one’s profession. It is suggestive from the responses that the tattoo with which the modern Jew engages is primarily a permanent means of self-expression to remind one of important moments in one’s life and the values contained therein.

However, for a small percentage of modern Jews the act of tattooing may not be expressive but effective, as respondents believe the tattoo can evoke a substantive power in the lives of the marked individual. According to the 27 year-old from Vermont, “I chose that area [i.e. right hip] because when I get pregnant, and I intend to, the location of the tattoo will make it appear that the hand [of God] is cradling the baby...The idea was for it to protect me and promote good energy.” The tattoo as a mark which imbues the

bearer with strength during the precarious moments of life is also shared by the 42 year-old respondent from Ohio. After surviving one trauma, the Jewish male envisioned a tattoo that would be a “source of strength in all times of darkness.” Whether as effective or expressive marks, it is suggested that the “voluntary adornment/mutilation is an inherent part of experiencing the human condition...if we do experience them as observers or as the subject(s) we stand to gain a broader understanding of our relationships we have to our existential world.”²

Yet the observation of this part of the human condition is often restricted by the inconspicuous places the tattoo is made on the human body. Out of the 11 respondents, only two chose highly visible locations for the tattoo, such as the forearm or neck. As it was recognized by one respondent, a mental adjustment is made when one chooses a more conspicuous place. According to the 43 year-old from Oklahoma, who is tattooed multiple times on the forearms, “This ‘leap’ to more visible areas of my body was a conscious decision that took me from the modest phase of being tattooed to the vanity phase.” In fact, most respondents – and it may be suggestive for tattooing among Jews in general – confine tattooing to its modest presentation as an overwhelming number of these individuals chose areas of the body that could be easily hidden by clothing: ankle, stomach, back, hip, upper thigh and upper arm.

The choice to adorn the body in these private places has two primary motivations: personal and public. A Jew may tattoo on an area of the body out of view of others because of the perceived private worth of the tattoo. This value is articulated in the response of the 27 year-old from Vermont. She wrote, “My tattoo was for me. Nobody

2. *Ibid.*

else.” Personal worth was not the only motivating factor guiding the private placement of the tattoo. According to the 42 year-old respondent from Ohio, professional reasons also play a role in where the modern Jew tattoos. He wrote:

“As a rabbi...I am a role model to people...I need to be seriously careful about the aspects of my life that are public. [For this] reason I chose to get the tattoo in a place that I could show it to people that I want to show it to.”

Inherent in the rabbi’s reasoning is concern for the public’s perception of the tattoo. Although it has been acknowledged that a shift has occurred in the general public’s perception of tattoos, that shift may not be as pervasive in the Jewish world, as even the Jewish respondents admit that at some point in life “visible tattoos are tacky.”³ Others simply avoid the potentially awkward social situation by showing it only to “people who are not judgmental about tattoos.”⁴

Although it was not directly spoken of in the responses of the tattooed Jews, one may wonder if the private placement of the tattoo also signals a silent confession of the communal stigma against tattooing in Judaism. “There is a stigma, I suppose, but I don’t feel it,” wrote the 27 year-old from Vermont. Out of the 11 respondents, 10 were aware of the tattoo taboo in Judaism prior to the decision to be tattooed. “Yes,” answered the 29 year-old from Massachusetts, “the taboo against tattooing was a part of my religion and I was aware of it.” However, only three out of these 10 respondents correlate their informed status of the Jewish prohibition against tattooing to scripture, either Biblical or

3. The belief that visible tattoos are tacky comes from the female respondent from Massachusetts. It is also a thought shared by the 27 year-old respondent from Vermont. She wrote: “I knew that I did not want to get a visible tattoo. I dreaded the thought of being 80 and having some awkward tattoo imprinted on a clear and visible body part.”

4. And, the concern about people who may be judgmental of people with tattoos comes from the 58 year-old respondent from Ohio.

rabbinic. The 42 year-old from Ohio stated, “I needed to examine the decision seriously... I started looking at the Torah text and then I moved to the *Mishnah* and Talmud.” In addition to these early works of Jewish tradition, another respondent considered modern rabbinic positions. “In my decision to be tattooed...I began exploring the Jewish religious perspective on tattooing,” stated the 30 year-old from Ohio. A Conservative rabbi “presented me with the Conservative responsum on the topic and said that if I desired to continue to work with children it would be advantageous to be informed.”

In truth, the responses suggest that a majority of the Jewish community is actually ill-informed or incorrectly informed about the prohibition on tattooing. Out of the 11 respondents, six believe the taboo against tattooing has a direct correlation to a ban on Jewish burial. This incorrect teaching is perpetuated, in part, by parents: “My parents had always told me that if I got a tattoo I couldn’t be buried in a Jewish cemetery.”⁵ Despite parental attempts to steer their children away from the practice by perpetuating the misconception, the ban-on-burial seems to lack real potency. For some, the supposed ban is ineffective due to a lack of concern for the afterlife. As the 21 year-old Israeli writes: “It really doesn’t matter if I will not be buried in a Jewish cemetery. I will be dead.”⁶ For others, though, belief – rather than disbelief – actually counters the supposed ban. “Yes, I thought about religious so-called consequences,” wrote the 27 year-old from Arizona, “but I believed that God or whatever higher power there is won’t judge us in the end whether or not we decorate ourselves.” While religious beliefs, whether correctly

5. This statement comes from the 29 year-old female respondent from O’Fallon, Missouri.

6. A disregard for an afterlife is not just felt among the young. The 43 year-old from Oklahoma wrote: “I have never really appreciated or understood why we (Western human society) place so much value in burial. I admit, I have never researched the history of it either, so my lack of appreciation is somewhat out of ignorance. But, from a gut level and from an intellectual/emotional perspective I am much more inclined towards cremation of human remains.”

understood or not, are often considered in the decision to be or not to be tattooed, for many Jews these communal beliefs do not override one's sense of personal autonomy. The respondent from Vermont wrote, "I knew I could not be buried in a Jewish cemetery once I got one, but religion has never run my life."

Of greater influence in the contemporary Jew's life – specifically the decision to be tattooed – is the perception of previous generations, not in terms of religious traditions, but in terms of parental concerns and historical circumstances. Out of the 11 respondents, six recognized that the decision to be tattooed raised tension with a loved one, particularly in the parent-child relationship. The generational tension may be heard in the response of the 29 year-old from Missouri. She shared that her "parents were very disappointed...when they found out about the tattoo. [And,] it upset me that my own personal decision to have a tattoo was something my parents used to look down on me." Wishing to avoid the negative reaction, some respondents, like the one from Massachusetts decided to hide the tattoo from their parents. "My parents are very against tattoos and I didn't (and even at almost 30 [years-old] I continue to not) want them to see it."⁷

Other tattooed Jews, however, decided to confront their parents' concerns and aversive reactions. At times, this response came through direct conversations. According to the respondent from Vermont, "I am extremely close with my mother and father and would never, even have gotten a tattoo if I thought that it would jeopardize my relationship with either of them. However I needed them to know how important it was to me...I told them

7. The 27 year-old from Arizona also decided to hide her tattoo from her parents. She stated that the choice to be tattooed on the lower back near the tailbone was because "it is a spot that I was able to hide it [i.e. the tattoo] from my family."

that.” At other times, those Jews who desired a tattoo attempted to pacify the concerns of the previous generation through the tattoo itself. Once again, the 29 year-old from Missouri wrote, “Having the Hebrew on my body rather than some random butterfly made me feel even closer to the religion. It helped me to believe that I wasn’t the ‘bad Jew’ that my parents tried to make me into.” Although parental concerns were considered by many of the respondents, these concerns were not enough to persuade the next generation from being tattooed. “I did momentarily consider how my mother, who is no longer living, would react to my being tattooed,” stated the 43 year-old respondent from Oklahoma. “It was a passing consideration that was quickly trumped by my personal interest in permanent body art.”

Personal interest also triumphed over the perception of the Holocaust generation on the practice of tattooing. Out of 11 respondents, five brought up the issue of the Holocaust – a moment when Jews were forcibly tattooed on their forearms as a way to remove their humanity and turn them into numbers. According to the 29 year-old respondent from Massachusetts, “My grandmother was in Auschwitz and certainly I have always associated their [i.e. the Holocaust generation and those immediately afterward] feelings on tattoos with the mandatory tattooing done on the victims there.” Even so, the circumstances of the Holocaust do not have the affect some would imagine on the contemporary Jew’s choice to be tattooed. For example, the respondent from California decided to be tattooed *because* of the Holocaust, incising a Star of David on his chest in the same spot his relatives were forced to embroider the yellow Star of David on their clothing. According to his statement, this tattoo served as a “memorial and a reminder” to them. If the Holocaust was not a motivation for the tattoo, then at least the conscripted

tattoos of that period brought meaning into the voluntary act of tattooing for some modern Jews. The 33 year-old from Ohio conveyed that her, “*Emunah* tattoo honors their struggle of survival, and to a certain extent, expresses the idea that modern Jews have the choice of being tattooed with Jewish symbols that bring glory to Judaism rather than shame.”

While some Jews do not and will not see their Judaism in relation to the Holocaust, the 33 year-old respondent above may have a point: Jews are making the choice to be tattooed with a Jewish symbol as a way to bring meaning to their Jewish lives. In fact out of the 11 respondents, five chose a Jewish symbol as their mark-of-choice. For some, tattooing a Jewish symbol seemed to mitigate the tension between personal desires and communal values of Judaism, as is heard from the respondent from Vermont: “I could almost justify getting something [i.e. the tattoo] that was frowned upon in my religion by getting a religious symbol.” Echoing that sentiment, the respondent from Missouri wrote:

“If I was going to be going against Judaism, I may as well do it right.

Some may believe that this makes no sense, but to me it was perfectly clear. Judaism has and always will be an important part of who I am.

Having the Hebrew on my body rather than some random butterfly made me feel even closer to the religion.”

It can be suggested that tattooing Jewish symbols not only has the effect of bringing one closer to religion, but the tattoo could actually be used to present one’s faith in Judaism. As the 30 year-old male respondent from Ohio spoke about the tattoo on his back, “This expresses my perspective on life, balancing my affection for my particular Jewish faith with my universal faith in human kind under one God.” Faith was also expressed literally

on the body of the 33 year-old from Ohio as she tattooed the Hebrew word *Emunah* (meaning: faith) on her ankle. “I chose *Emunah* because when I converted to Judaism...I finally learned what faith meant: Even though you can’t touch it, see it, rationalize it, it is still possible and it can happen.” Thus, tattooing a Jewish symbol may be a means among contemporary Jews to tangibly connect to something that appears intangible, such as faith. A similar sentiment is, after all, conveyed in the Bible and is reiterated three times daily in Jewish prayer: “Bind them as a sign upon your hand; let them be a symbol before your eyes.”⁸ Although this line speaks metaphorically to binding the intangible concept of God’s commandments to one’s life, Jews over the centuries have manifested this idea physically in the placement of *tefilin* (phylacteries) on the forehead and around the arm. In a similar way, some contemporary Jews choose to tattoo as a means to manifest physically the intangible notion of binding one’s life to the faith and teachings of Judaism. The tattoo of a Jewish emblem is literally the “sign upon the hand” and the “symbol before their eyes.” Because of the tattoo’s function as a symbol of Jewish pride, one respondent even advocated: “Be proud of who you are. Be proud of being Jewish. Get a Jewish symbol tattooed on your body and be proud of it!”⁹

As a result of its potential use in Judaism and its growing acceptance in the general public, 9 out of the 11 respondents are convinced that tattooing will become an accepted practice in Judaism. The other two were not really voices of opposition, but resisted answering conclusively due to uncertainty. As one of these two respondents questioned: “Is there a common ground on which tattooing can expand the perspective of modern Judaism and is there common ground on which modern Judaism can expand the

8. Deuteronomy 6:8

9. This statement comes from the 42 year-old respondent from Ohio.

perspective of tattooing?”¹⁰ An answer to this question is suggested in the response of the 30 year-old from Ohio. He wrote that the common ground may be found in the spirit of Jewish law and the meaning imbued in modern tattooing.

“From my understanding of the prohibition...tattooing was forbidden as a way to make the Israel nation and its members distinct from its neighbors.

Does not the tattooing of Jewish symbols and messages accomplish this task – distinguishing an individual as a Jew?”

In the end, however, there can be no certainty as to how tattoos will play out in the future of the Jewish world. One respondent suggested that “perhaps a historian should research this [topic] and spark a conversation among rabbis and Jews.”¹¹ While it is the hope of this thesis to be the spark which ignites that conversation in the Jewish community, maybe – as one respondent offered – all we can do for now is “hope that...God still loves [us], despite [our] actions.”¹²

10. The question was asked by the respondent from Oklahoma.

11. The suggestion was proposed by the 33 year-old female respondent from Ohio.

12. This hope comes in the response of the 27 year-old woman from Vermont.